

home team's cause either.

India, which had so far looked unconvincing in parts, was unravelling. It headed to Indore, needing a win against England.

A day before Diwali, the Indian management dropped quite a bomb by dropping Jemimah, who had until then returned scores of 0, 32, 0, and 33, to accommodate Renuka. India picked form over skill set, as Jemimah's meticulous approach to grinding out runs would have solved India's scoring issues at number 3.

The Renuka punt didn't work, with England managing 289 courtesy of a brilliant 109 by Heather Knight.

Now a batter short, the Indian seniors needed to take responsibility, and they did. Powered by fifties from Smriti and Harmanpreet, India's equation was a doable 23 off 12. But a familiar crumble ensued, with India falling four runs short.

This made the next fixture against New Zealand a must-win clash.

India had a whole playlist of countless instances where the side looked solid in a game but botched the finish. The tear-stained faces of Mithali Raj, Jhulan Goswami, and even a young and inconsolable Shafali Verma from that 2020 T20 World Cup final in Melbourne made an appearance in this mash-up.

With the pressure building, India made its way to Navi Mumbai, the unofficial hub of women's cricket in the country.

India needed that, especially after the dressing down the side got from coach Muzumdar for making the same mistakes.

Smriti and Pratika exorcised their demons with a massive 212-run opening stand, which saw both openers register centuries. An explosive unbeaten 76 from Jemimah, who was promptly called

back into the XI, helped the side to 340 in a rain-curtailed game.

India's bowling was far too good for the White Ferns, with Renuka and Kranti leading the pack with two wickets apiece. That 53-run win (DLS method) effectively sealed India's place in the top four.

The final league clash against Bangladesh, which was washed out, brought a devastating twist to India's campaign. Pratika slipped awkwardly on a wet outfield and sustained a hairline fracture to the ankle.

Around 290 kilometres away in Surat, Shafali Verma — who had been cast aside from the ODI setup for inconsistency a year ago — was in the middle of an imperious run in the Senior Women's T20 Trophy for Haryana. She didn't

even make the reserves listed for the tournament, but the management went directly to her,



True all-rounder: Deepti Sharma is the first player to do the double of 200-plus runs and 20-plus wickets in a World Cup, having scored 215 runs, including three fifties, and taken two four-plus wicket hauls.

EMMANUEL YOGINI

hoping to tap into her ache for redemption.

"God has brought me here for a reason. I will do my best for the team," Shafali said.

South Africa had thrown the albatross called England off its neck in Guwahati and admitted to backing India to make the final.

In the semifinal, Phoebe Litchfield's masterclass propelled Australia to a formidable 338.

The heroes of a stiff chase had to be the messiah of 2017 — Harmanpreet — with Jemimah, who looked in fine touch. The pair put their heads down, scoring at six per over at least, with the Aussies getting impatient for a breakthrough. The nerves of it all saw Healy drop Jemimah on 82. India needed 131 runs in a little over 17 overs.

However, Harmanpreet, Deepti, and Richa fell in quick succession, and an old tendency to fall like ninepins threatened to resurface. Jemimah, meanwhile, rang in a century, her first in World Cups, but refused to celebrate. The job was not done.

Tahlia McGrath then dropped a straightforward chance to give Jemimah another lifeline on 106. India needed 54 from 41 balls. The final few overs felt like a final rather than a semifinal, with Jemimah and Amanjot finishing the job with nine balls to spare.

The images of that finish will be tattooed on the brains of anyone who watched the game. A sobbing Jemimah, her teammates piled in a mound over her. Harmanpreet roared loud enough for someone to hear it on the moon: India had beaten the best side in the world. Surely this was the year!

Jemimah bawled her way through multiple interviews, revealing her struggles with anxiety and the devastation of getting dropped midway through the tournament. She spoke about crying to her mother and close teammates every day and needing to do something for India to trust that she belonged on the biggest stage.

"We were talking about what we